

Every Exit

by Douglxss Burley Johnson

My right boot hit the edge of a concrete loading pad and skidded on grit, and I caught the cold steel of a roll-up track with both hands before the bay door finished its climb and threw the dark shed open behind us.

I ran with Quinn Harlow half a stride left and a fifty-pound bag of concrete mix already burning my forearms through the work gloves. The Packerton transfer sheds stretched west of Jim Thorpe in a broken line of brick and corrugated iron, old Lehigh Valley Railroad classification ground gone to weeds and pigeons, and the air in that first bay smelled of dry cement, diesel ghosts, and the sharp dust that rises when you kick a pallet that has sat too long. My name is Cal Merritt. I was twenty-three that night. We had come in off the Lehigh side because a man in a faded clerk's coat had stepped out from between two dead gondolas and started after us without calling our names, and the sheds were the only cover that did not run us straight back into his hands on the open yard.

"Bay three," Quinn said. "We brace that door and we cut out the far personnel door to the service road."

"If it stays shut," I said.

"It stayed shut last spring when we staged the pier pour for the borough. Same roll-up. Same latch bar."

I knew that door. Everybody who had hauled mix through Packerton in the last five years knew it. A wide roll-up on a concrete apron, chain hoist on the right, latch bar that dropped into a floor socket, and a row of leftover cinder blocks stacked against the west wall like somebody meant to finish a job and never came back. In daylight the bay stood open so trucks could back in. After dark the old yard men who still talked about Packerton said you did not leave a transfer door open once the light failed, because a shed is a mouth and a mouth that stays open after dark invites what wants a way through.

We had left three doors open ourselves on the way in, chasing a rattle that turned out to be a raccoon on a pallet rack. Then the clerk stepped out from between the gondolas with boots that hit gravel in a meter no tired man uses, and we ran into the sheds because the open yard was a dead field against his coat and the sheds at least had doors.

Cement grit rolled under my boots. Pallets showed gray in Quinn's phone light and then vanished when she killed the beam. Water dripped from a rust hole in the roof into a dented drum, a thin cold talk that kept time the whole length of the bay. Behind us the clerk's boots entered the mouth we had left open, and the sound of them came down the concrete even and sure, the way a hammer finds the same nail.

I shifted the bag higher against my chest and kept running.

"Cal," Quinn said. "Your aunt's lines. Do them if you have to. Just do not stop for a speech."

"I am not stopping," I said.

Aunt Della had taught me the short work on her back steps the summer I turned seventeen, after a bad night on the old shop road when my mouth went empty and every door I shut swung open again behind me like it had a hand on the other side. She did not give me a sermon. She gave me three lines and told me to say them while my feet kept moving.

"Jesus, hold the latch. Shut what wants back in. Keep my hands on the weight."

I said the first line under my breath now, boots striking concrete, bag edges cutting my arms, and the shed walls threw the words back in a thin echo that died against corrugated iron.

Behind us the clerk came on. In a scrap of sky light through a broken clerestory I saw the coat, gray wool gone green at the cuffs, and under the brim a face that had been a yard man's face and was learning a different set of bones. His mouth hung open on a dry sound, as if he were tasting dust. His hands hung too long at the ends of the sleeves. He did not call out. He did not need to. The open roll-ups behind him were doing the calling for both of us.

Quinn swore once, soft, the way she does when a form fails on a job, and put on speed.

We hit the first personnel door between bay one and bay two. Quinn shoved it shut with her shoulder. The latch clicked. Three heartbeats later the latch popped like a cheap lock under a crowbar, and the door swung wide again with a sigh of hinge rust. Cold air from the yard poured through. The clerk walked the reopened door as if reopening were the only work left in him.

"He opens what we shut," Quinn said.

"Because every exit reopens until hands put weight on it," I said. "Aunt Della said a door with no weight after dark is a latch with the pin out."

"Your aunt said a lot of things. Run."

We ran. Bay two held a row of empty bag pallets and a stack of cinder blocks under a tarp. My left palm burned where the roll-up track had taken skin on the first grab. Halfway through, a floor drain grate sat proud of the slab and I nearly put a boot into that hole and caught myself on the bag jammed against a post. Quinn grabbed my jacket collar and hauled me clear without slowing her own stride.

"Watch the grate," she said.

"I see it now."

Behind us the clerk took the grate crossing without a stumble. His coat brushed a pallet edge and left a smear of gray dust that smelled worse than wet cement when we passed the place later in memory. Ahead, faded Lehigh Valley stencil lettering still clung to a steel beam, letters half eaten by rust, and the beam threw a pale rectangle that helped me mark distance to bay three.

Quinn's phone light flicked once more, found the roll-up ahead as a black rectangle against a lighter dark, and went off again so we would not paint a target on our backs.

A loose chain hung from the hoist. I kicked it aside rather than risk a turn of the ankle. The chain rang once on concrete and then the shed ate the sound. Wrong meter of boots ate our lead and left no room for jokes.

Short work kept going in a hard whisper that cost breath I wanted for the run. The clerk answered with that dry pull of breath, closer now, and I heard his coat slap a door frame and tear. Cloth sound. Wrong body sound under it, like dry rope on a winch.

Quinn reached bay three first. The roll-up hung halfway open, latch bar dangling, floor socket empty, and the leftover cinder blocks waited under the tarp against the west wall like a job half finished. She put both hands on the chain and hauled.

The door moved two feet and stuck. Rust and cold and a bend in the track from years of trucks hitting the jamb. She hauled again. The door groaned and stuck harder.

"Cal. Door."

I got there with the bag already coming off my chest. Behind us the clerk cleared bay two and the shed threw his dry breath ahead of him like weather. I set the bag on the apron, grabbed the chain with Quinn, and threw my weight on the pull. Iron complained. The door jumped another foot and hung.

"Again," Quinn said.

We drove together, her hands on the chain, my boots planted on grit. The roll-up came down in a hard run and slammed toward the sill. It hit the floor lip and bounced, refused the seat, and hung crooked while the clerk's boots ate the last fifty yards of slab in that even wrong meter.

"Latch," I said.

"I know."

Quinn grabbed the latch bar. I got both hands under the bottom rail and shoved it the last inch to the sill while she drove the bar toward the floor socket. The socket took the bar with a dull iron knock that ran up the posts. Latch iron seated crooked and the door shuddered.

The clerk's boots hit the door from outside.

His hands, too long in the sleeves, closed on the bottom rail from our side of the apron. Fingers bent wrong at the first knuckle. The coat smelled of dry cement and old carbon paper and a sweet rot that did not belong on a living clerk. His face came up against the gap above the sill, and under the brim his eyes held too steady, the way a nail holds when you have already bent it and kept hammering.

"Open," he said. The voice was a clerk's voice rubbed down to dust. "The exits stay open. I need the mouths."

Quinn drove the latch a second time. Rust held the socket shallow. My shoulders shook under the rail while the door lifted a finger's width against my hands.

I could have kept talking. Short work still sat in my mouth. I shut my mouth and saved the breath for my shoulders.

Silence hit the shed like a dropped plank.

On the far side of the rail the clerk pulled and the whole door shuddered without giving fully. Without the short work in the air his strength climbed. Against my palms the rail lifted another half inch. Quinn's boots slid on grit. On its hinge the latch bar danced and would not stay true in the socket.

"Cal," Quinn said. "Talk or stack. Pick one."

I stacked.

I left the rail for one hard second, spun to the tarp, and tore it back. Cinder blocks sat in a short wall, eight of them, heavy and cold. I grabbed the first block with both hands, spun back, and set it hard against the bottom rail on our side. Quinn understood without a word. She took the next block while I took the third. We built a brace in a rush of scraped knuckles and grit, two high, three deep at the center, concrete against steel, weight against the lift.

The clerk hauled. The rail rose against the blocks and the blocks held. Dust sifted off the top course onto my boots.

I put the short work back into the air, quiet, while my hands stayed on the top block.

"Jesus, hold the latch. Shut what wants back in. Keep my hands on the weight."

The clerk's pull failed a fraction. His long fingers slid on the rail. He stepped left along the apron and found the personnel door at the side of bay three, the thin exit we had meant to use for the service road, and that door, which Quinn had shoved shut on the way in, swung open under his hand as if it had been waiting for him.

"Side door," Quinn said.

"I see it."

I left the block stack for the bag I had dropped. The fifty-pound mix was still sealed, paper dusty, Portland printed half worn. I hauled it to the personnel door while Quinn held the roll-up brace with her shoulder and both palms. The clerk was already in the side frame, dry breath filling the gap. I swung the bag low and hard into the door, slam against the jamb, and the door bounced shut on his coat sleeve. He pulled the sleeve free with a sound like paper tearing. I threw my hip into the door, dropped the bag against the threshold as a wedge, and stacked two more bags from the nearest pallet on top of the first until the paper tore and gray powder spilled across the sill in a soft hill.

"Pin the latch," I said.

Quinn left the roll-up for three strides, drove a spare hitch pin from her jacket pocket through the personnel door hasp, and bent the pin with the heel of her glove the way you bend a cotter when you do not trust a spring. Then she was back at the blocks, adding a fourth course while I poured a fifth bag against the bottom rail of the roll-up until the paper split and the mix spread like a low dam.

The clerk hauled on the roll-up from outside. The blocks shifted a finger's width and settled. Powder from the spilled bags rose in a gray cloud that tasted of lime and cold. His face pressed the gap above the rail and the dry sound in his mouth went thin, then sour, then broke

into a cough that belonged to a man who had walked this yard in a living year and did not understand why the mouths had closed on him.

I kept the short work in the air while my hands pressed the top block true.

"Jesus, hold the latch. Shut what wants back in. Keep my hands on the weight."

The clerk's pull failed. The clerk's long fingers slid off the rail. His boot heels found the apron again with the braced door between us and the yard dark rising behind him. His coat hung wrong on ribs that had learned a new cage, and those steady eyes found the blocks and the spilled mix the way a dog finds a door that used to open.

"You left them open," he said. "I came because they were open."

"We closed them," I said.

"Closing costs," he said. "Your aunt knows. Tell her the yard remembers the clerks who counted cars sober and the ones who did not."

Without another word the coat turned and walked back along the apron into the dark between the sheds, boots even, wool torn, and the dry pull of breath faded under the drip in the drum until bay three held only concrete and cold and our own lungs.

Quinn slid down the block stack until she sat on the apron with her back to the rail. She peeled her right glove off and looked at the heel where she had bent the hitch pin. The leather had split. Blood showed dark in the phone light when she flicked it on for three seconds and killed it again.

"You went quiet," she said.

"Hands needed the air," I said. "It cost us. He got stronger while I shut up."

"I saw that." She flexed the split glove. "I also saw a dead clerk's coat try to pull a roll-up out of a concrete sill. I am not joining your aunt's church because a bag of mix held a door."

"I know."

Night wind came up off the Lehigh and neither of us filled it. Quinn wanted a box labeled adrenaline and bad light and a story she could tell at the pier job without sounding soft. I did not give her the box. My hands stayed on the top block, fingers checking the seat, then letting it alone.

We walked the open service road east toward the spot where Quinn had left her truck under a sumac cluster off the Jim Thorpe side. Behind us bay three held shut, latch bar home, blocks braced, bags spilled into a gray dam against the sill. No coat reappeared at the rail. Crickets had started again in the weed edge. I wiped blood from my left palm onto my jeans and kept a spare hitch pin in my pocket. At the truck the hood was cold and dew had started on the windshield. Quinn unlocked the doors with a hand that still shook once and then stopped shaking because she refuses to let fear finish a sentence. She rode us out toward the blacktop with the heater on low and her split glove in her lap.

At Aunt Della's porch the kitchen light was still on. Della took one look at my raw palms and Quinn's split glove and put a dish towel under my hands without asking for the long version first.

"You closed them," she said.

"Roll-up and side door," I said. "He was in the sheds because we left the mouths open. He needed the exits. While I shut up to stack, he got stronger. When the weight sat and I put the short work back, he could not finish the pull."

Della poured coffee that had sat too long and set the mug where I could reach it. She turned my hands palm up and clicked her tongue at the grit still in the scrapes. "A shed is a

mouth. A mouth with the latch off after dark is an invitation. Prayer is hands on the weight as much as words in the air."

Quinn stood by the porch rail with her jacket still zipped and shook her head once, done talking for the night.

"I'll grant the stop at the door," she said. "I will not grant a Person on the other end of your aunt's three lines before I have a bandage and a beer. Cal, text me when your hands are cleaned up. I need a new glove and a story for the pier job that does not mention clerks in abandoned yards."

Quinn left, and the screen door slapped. Aunt Della washed the grit out of my palms under cold water and checked the block scrape across my thumb under the porch light. She did not ask me to preach what had happened. She handed me the towel and told me to come back in the morning to walk bay three in daylight and make sure the latch still sat true.

On the table by the door her late husband's combination square still lay where he had left it the week before the cancer took him, brass and steel, the blade dull with shop oil. Della had been a carpenter's wife for thirty years and kept his tools because tools remember work better than talk does. No book opened at me that night. Soft, she said a good teacher can tell you how to cut a joint, and a Person can hold a door when your hands are already on the weight, and those are not the same claim.

I am twenty-seven now. I still drive the service road west of Jim Thorpe when the light is low. The Packerton sheds still hold their concrete pads and their rusted roll-ups and their pigeon nests in the clerestory. Contractors leave the doors open in daylight and mostly remember to drop them before they go home. Quinn still sits across from me at the diner on Broadway in Jim Thorpe and argues that prayer is a noise useful people make when a latch sticks. She will grant

the stop at the door. She will not grant a Person who answers three short lines while your hands are under a block.

I keep three spare hitch pins in the glove box of my truck. On nights when the wind comes up the yard smelling of dry cement and leaf rot, I check that the bay three latch still falls true. I do not open the sheds after dark for a dare. I do not preach the door at Quinn. When a mouth that should be shut is hanging open and a wrong clerk is already in the bay, my boots already know the pads, and my hands find the weight while my mouth finds the short work Aunt Della taught me on the back steps.

If you ever run the abandoned Packerton transfer sheds west of Jim Thorpe after the light fails and hear boots that hit concrete wrong behind you, shut the bay with your hands and your cargo before you make a speech in the dark. Along that old classification ground the veil thins in the cold hour, and every exit reopens until the weight holds, and the latch still fits the socket.

END